

Everything you need to run an event.

A start-to-finish guide to the events system on your website: putting an event up, building the sign-up form, taking payment, managing who's coming, and checking people in on the day.

Written for whoever's doing the job, not for a developer. Nothing here needs any technical knowledge.

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SECTION 1

Getting in

Log in to your website's admin area — usually your address with `/wp-admin` on the end — and look for **Church Events** in the black menu down the left-hand side.

IF YOU CAN'T SEE THE MENU

The events system is only visible to people set up as an **Administrator** on the website. If you've been given a login and there's no "Church Events" in the menu, your account doesn't have the right level of access yet.

That's not something you can change yourself, and it isn't a fault. Ask whoever manages the website, or get in touch with us and we'll sort it.

There's no separate "volunteer login" — everyone who works on events uses the same admin area and sees the same screens. Two of them, **Settings** and **Support**, stay restricted to the main website administrator even when everything else is available to you.

SECTION 2

The screens

Everything lives under the one **Church Events** menu. Here's what each item is for.

Church Events

Dashboard — the overview: totals, who signed up recently, what's coming up

All Events — every event you've made, past and future

Add New Event — start a new one

Registrations — every sign-up, for every event. Where you'll spend most of your time

Groups — ongoing small groups (not one-off events)

Add New Group — start a new small group

Group Sign-ups — who has joined which group

Check-In — the screen you use on the day of the event

Email Center — email everyone signed up, and check whether emails are arriving

Reports — numbers over a date range, and attendance

Settings — church name, email addresses, payments (administrator only)

Support — send us a message directly from your site (administrator only)

The **Dashboard** is worth a look each week. The cards across the top — **Events** , **People Signed Up** , **Signed Up Today** , **Coming Up** , **Needs Approval** , **Waiting List** — are clickable, and most of them jump you straight to the right filtered list.

SECTION 3

Putting on an event

Go to **Church Events** › **Add New Event**. Give it a title at the top and write whatever you want people to read in the big box underneath — that's the event page itself.

Then work down the boxes below it.

When & Where

- **Starts** and **Ends** — the date and time.
- **Venue / room** , **Street address** , **Google Maps link** — as much or as little as you like.
- Tick **This is an online or hybrid event** and a **Stream link** box appears for your Zoom or YouTube address.

- **Cost per registration** – leave it blank to show no price at all. Put **0.00** to display the word "Free".
- **Status** – **Active** , **Postponed** or **Cancelled** . Postponing or cancelling puts a notice on the event page and stops new sign-ups.

Sign-Up Settings

This is where the sign-up form gets set up.

- **Enable registration form** – on by default. Turn it off for an event that's just an announcement with no sign-up.
- **Maximum attendees** – the total you can take. **0 means unlimited.**
- **Guests per sign-up** – how many people one person can register at once. Leave it at 1 and everyone signs up individually; set it to 6 and someone can bring their whole family in one go.
- **Sign-up deadline** – sign-ups close automatically at this date and time.
- **Sign-up status** – **Open** or **Closed** , if you want to close it by hand.

EASY TO MISS

Everything in **Sign-Up Settings** greys out and stops working if **Enable registration form** is unticked. Your settings aren't lost – tick it again and they all come back.

Different prices for different people

The **Pricing tiers** section handles things like Adult \$25 / Student \$10 / Child free. Click **+** **Add Registration Type** for each one and fill in the **Type Name** , **Price** , **Capacity** (0 for unlimited) and a **Description** if it needs explaining.

Two things worth knowing:

- **Heading shown to registrants** lets you replace the default title above the choices with your own wording, like "Which session are you attending?". Leave it blank to keep the standard text.
- **Allow mixed quantities across tiers** changes the form completely. Off, people pick **one** type. On, they choose a quantity for each – so one person can book 2 adults and 2 children together, and the total adds up as they go.

THEN

Click **Publish** and the event is live. Before you tell anyone, open the event page yourself and sign up as a test – it's the fastest way to catch a wrong price or a missing question. Delete your test sign-up afterwards.

Your sign-up form

Everyone is asked for a first name, last name, email and phone number. Anything else you need goes in the **Registration Form Fields** box on the event.

Click **+ Add Field** and you get a row with a **Label** (the question), a **Type**, an **Options / Limits** area, and two tick boxes: **Required** and **Per person**.

The question types

TYPE	USE IT FOR
Text	A short answer on one line
Paragraph	A longer answer, like dietary needs or a prayer request
Email	A second email address
Phone	An emergency contact number
Number	An age, or how many seats in their car
Date	A date of birth
Dropdown	Pick one from a long list
Multiple Choice	Pick one from a short list, all options visible
Checkboxes	Pick as many as apply
Waiver/Agreement	Text they must read and tick to accept

Putting a limit on an option

For **Dropdown**, **Multiple Choice** and **Checkboxes**, each option gets its own **Limit** box. Use it for workshops, seatings, or minibus places.

- Leave a limit blank or 0 and that option is unlimited.
- People see **"12 spots left"** beside a capped option, and **"Full"** once it's gone. A full option can't be chosen.
- The count is checked again when they submit, so a busy evening can't push an option past its limit.
- Once people start choosing, the editor shows **"N signed up"** next to each option.
- Option labels can't contain commas — type one and it becomes a space when you save.

Asking each person separately

Tick **Per person** and the question repeats for everybody on a sign-up instead of being asked once for the whole booking.

This is what you want for a retreat where one person books their family and each of them needs their own workshop choice. The form grows a card per person: the first is the person booking, and the rest ask for a name plus their own answers.

- **Guests per sign-up** has to be more than 1 for this to be any use — that's the setting that lets someone book more than themselves.
- One person can book up to **25 people** at a time.
- Leave **Per person** off for anything that applies to the booking as a whole, like "how did you hear about this?".

WORTH KNOWING

If someone picks an answer by mistake on a question that isn't required, there's a **Clear selection** link under the options. Clicking the chosen option a second time clears it too.

SECTION 5

Taking payment

There are three ways an event can work, and which one you get depends on the price and one tick box.

YOU WANT

SET IT UP LIKE THIS

Free

Leave **Cost per registration** blank, or set it to 0.00 to show the word "Free"

Pay on the day

Enter a price and tick **Allow attendees to pay at the door**. People sign up without paying and the event tells them payment is due when they arrive

Card payment now

Enter a price, leave the pay-at-the-door box unticked, and make sure card payments are switched on in Settings

Card payments run through Stripe and are set up once, by your administrator, under **Settings › Payments**. Card details are never stored on your website.

BEFORE YOUR FIRST PAID EVENT

Test it properly. In Settings there's a **Test mode** option and a test card number you can use to run a fake payment end to end. Do that once, on a hidden event, before real money is involved.

Managing sign-ups

Church Events › Registrations lists every sign-up across every event. Narrow it down with the dropdowns along the top: by event, by status, by whether they've been checked in, by date, or by searching a name or email.

Looking at one person

Click someone's name to open their details: which event, their contact details, how many people they booked, their answers to your questions, and – if you used **Per person** questions – each individual person and what they chose.

From there you can **Check In**, **Edit Contact Info** (a mistyped email or a changed surname) or **Delete**.

Doing several at once

Tick the boxes down the left, choose from **Bulk Actions**, then click **Apply**. Your choices are **Mark Confirmed**, **Mark Checked In**, **Mark Cancelled**, **Send Reminder Email** and **Delete permanently**.

TWO THINGS THAT TRIP PEOPLE UP

Approving one person also happens through Bulk Actions – there's no approve button on the row itself. Tick just that one person, choose **Mark Confirmed**, click Apply.

Sending a reminder twice sends two emails. The automatic nightly reminder checks whether one already went out; the manual button doesn't. Click it once.

WHY THE WORDS DON'T MATCH

The status dropdown says **Pending**, **Confirmed**, **Checked In**. The coloured labels in the table say **Waiting for Approval**, **Approved**, **Here**. They mean the same things. Section 15 lines them all up.

SECTION 7

Spam sign-ups

Automated sign-ups are a fact of life on any public form. You'll know them when you see them: names that are a jumble of letters, and a random string of characters in the notes.

Your site now blocks these automatically, so you shouldn't see many. If some do get through:

- 1 Go to **Church Events › Registrations**.
- 2 Set the spam dropdown to **Likely spam only**.

- 3 Read down the list before you do anything.
Real people with unusual names are rare here but not impossible. Anything that looks like a person, leave alone.
- 4 Tick the box at the top of the table to select them all, choose **Delete permanently** , then **Apply** .

Under **Settings** › **Spam Protection** your administrator can see how many have been blocked and the last few that were turned away. That list is worth a glance now and then – if a real person's name appears in it, tell us and we'll adjust the filter.

IF SPAM KEEPS COMING

There's a free extra layer called Turnstile that stops it completely, and is invisible to your members. It needs a Cloudflare account and two keys pasting into Settings. Ask us and we'll set it up.

SECTION 8

The waiting list

When an event hits its **Maximum attendees** , new sign-ups go onto a waiting list instead of being turned away. They're told so on screen, and they show up in your list as **On Waiting List**.

- When somebody cancels, the **longest-waiting person is moved up automatically** and emailed to tell them they're in. You don't have to do anything.
- To move someone up by hand – say you've squeezed in extra chairs – click the up-arrow button on their row. If the event is still full it won't let you, so raise **Maximum attendees** first.
- To see just the waiting list, filter the status dropdown to **Waitlisted**, or click the **Waiting List** card on the Dashboard.

Emails

What sends on its own

EMAIL	WHEN
Confirmation	As soon as someone's sign-up is approved
Reminder	Automatically the day before (you can change how many days)
Cancellation	When a sign-up is cancelled
You're in!	When someone moves off the waiting list
New sign-up alert	To you, each time somebody registers

Something different for one event

Each event has a **Confirmation email** box: whatever you type there is added to that event's confirmation only, just under the event details. Use it for giving instructions, what to bring, or where to park. Paste a web address straight in and it becomes a link.

Emailing everyone yourself

Church Events › Email Center under **Compose & Send**. Pick the event, choose who gets it – **All registrants**, **Confirmed only**, **Pending only**, **Waitlist only**, **Checked-in attendees** or **No-shows** – then write it.

You can drop in **{first_name}**, **{event_title}**, **{event_date}** and similar, and each person gets their own details filled in.

Always click **Preview Recipients** first to see exactly who it's going to, and how many. Then send.

IF SOMEONE SAYS THEY NEVER GOT AN EMAIL

The **Email Log** tab shows every email your site tried to send and whether it went. The **Diagnostics** tab shows recent errors. Between them you can tell "we never sent it" from "we sent it and it's in their spam folder" – check there before assuming the worst.

Check-in day

DO THIS IN ADVANCE

Check-in is **off by default on every event**. Open the event, and in **Sign-Up Settings** tick **Enable check-in for this event**.

Until you do, the event won't appear on the Check-In screen at all, and nobody's confirmation email will include a QR code. If your event isn't in the list on the day, this is why – and it's a five-second fix on the event, not on the Check-In screen.

On the day, go to **Church Events › Check-In** and pick your event from the dropdown. Today's event usually selects itself. A tablet or laptop on the welcome desk works well.

- **By name** – type into the search box and tap the person to check them in. The button changes to "Checked In" so you can see at a glance who's arrived.
- **By QR code** – tap **Scan QR** to open the camera. It stays open and keeps scanning, so you can work through a queue without stopping. Each person's code is in their confirmation email.
- **Someone who didn't sign up** – tap **Add Walk-in**, enter a first and last name (email and phone are optional), and tap **Add & Check In**. They're registered and marked as here in one go.

A running count at the top shows how many have arrived out of how many signed up.

WALK-INS ALWAYS WORK

You can add a walk-in even when the event shows as full. That's deliberate – nobody standing in front of you gets turned away by a number on a screen. Just be aware it can take you over your stated capacity.

SECTION 11

Getting your list out

On **Registrations**, filter to what you want, then click **Export CSV**. You get exactly what's on screen – the filters carry through – as a file that opens in Excel, Numbers or Google Sheets.

You get a column for each of: name, email, phone, how many people, which pricing type, what they paid, status, when they signed up, when they were checked in, their notes, and a column for each of your own questions.

If you used **Per person** questions there's an **Attendees Detail** column reading something like "Jane Doe (Workshop: Pottery) | Amy Doe (Workshop: Journaling)" – enough to build your workshop lists in a spreadsheet.

Reports also has an **Export All as CSV** for a summary across events over a date range.

SECTION 12

Small groups

Groups are for things that meet again and again – a Tuesday Bible study, a men's breakfast – rather than a single event with a date.

Add one at **Church Events › Add New Group**. You describe it, pick a **Group type**, add one or more meeting times, set a capacity, say where it meets, and name a leader. Leader emails are for your records and aren't shown publicly.

Sign-up status controls what people see: **Open** takes new members, **Full** still shows the group but stops sign-ups, **Closed** stops them too, and **Inactive** hides it from the website altogether.

People who join show up under **Church Events › Group Sign-ups**, and the newest few are listed on the group itself.

Linking an event to a group

The **Group Events** box lets you attach an event to a group. Everyone in that group then gets a reminder about that event. Handy for a group's Christmas meal or a one-off outing.

ONE-TIME SETUP

Unlike events, there's no groups page created for you. Somebody needs to make a page, put **[cem_groups]** on it, and choose it under **Settings › Pages**. Without that, links to "the groups page" lead nowhere. Ask us if you're not sure whether it's been done.

SECTION 13

Settings

Administrator only, and mostly set once and left alone. The tabs are **General**, **Email**, **Registration**, **Payments**, **Spam Protection**, **Pages** and **Error Reporting**.

The handful you might actually touch:

Church Name	The name on your emails. Also changes "From Name" on the Email tab – they're the same setting
Admin Notify Email	Who gets told about new sign-ups. Several addresses allowed, separated by commas
Auto-confirm registrations	On, people are approved instantly. Off, everyone waits for you to approve them
Enable waitlist	Whether full events collect a waiting list
Send reminder N days before	How far ahead the automatic reminder goes out
Currency Symbol	The symbol shown next to prices

SAVE BEFORE YOU SWITCH TABS

Each tab saves on its own. Make a change on **General**, jump to **Email** without clicking **Save Settings**, and the first change is gone. Save, then move.

ONE THAT LOOKS EMPTY BUT ISN'T

Capacity alert threshold (%) on the Registration tab usually looks blank. Blank doesn't mean off – it behaves as **80%**, so you'll get an email when an event is 80% full. Put a number in if you want something different.

When something looks wrong

WHAT YOU'RE SEEING

WHAT TO CHECK

My event isn't on the Check-In screen

Open the event and tick **Enable check-in for this event** in Sign-Up Settings. That box, not the Check-In screen, is what puts it there

No sign-up form on the event page

Enable registration form is unticked, the **Sign-up deadline** has passed, or **Sign-up status** is set to Closed

Nobody can book more than one person

Guests per sign-up is still 1

My "per person" questions only ask once

Same thing – **Guests per sign-up** needs to be more than 1

Somebody says they got no confirmation

Email Center → **Email Log**. If it says Sent, it's their spam folder. If it isn't there at all, check **Diagnostics**

Event says full but I have room

Raise **Maximum attendees**, then promote people off the waiting list

A workshop shows Full too early

Check that option's **Limit**. Remember people waiting for approval are holding a place

Odd sign-ups with jumbled names

Spam. See section 7

I can't see the Church Events menu

Your login isn't an Administrator. See section 1

STILL STUCK

Church Events › Support sends us a message from inside your site, with the technical details attached automatically. Tell us what you expected and what happened instead, and we'll pick it up.

SECTION 15

The words we use

The same five states are worded differently in the filter dropdown and on the coloured labels. Here they are side by side.

FILTER SAYS	LABEL SAYS	MEANING
Pending	Waiting for Approval	Signed up, needs you to approve them
Confirmed	Approved	They're in, and they've had their confirmation
Checked In	Here	Arrived and checked in on the day
Waitlisted	On Waiting List	Event was full when they signed up
Cancelled	Cancelled	No longer coming. Frees their place

A few other terms

- **Registration** — one sign-up. May cover several people.
- **Attendee** — one person. A registration for a family of four is one registration, four attendees.
- **Pricing tier / registration type** — the same thing: Adult, Student, Child.
- **Capacity** — the most people you'll take. 0 means unlimited.
- **Registration code** — the short code on each sign-up. It's what the QR code holds, and how someone finds their own booking again.

White Oak Media

Something not behaving the way this describes? Send it over — either through **Church Events** › **Support** or straight to us.